

Daily Logic Drill #5 — Answers & Investigations

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Section	Topic	Questions	Target time
A	Rapid Recognition	10	2 min 30 sec
B	Manipulation Drills	10	8 min
C	Substitution & Structure	8	10 min
D	Challenge	5	15 min

New toolkit today: Spot the Flaw · Common Fallacies · Proof Critique · Valid vs. Invalid Arguments.

Section A

1. A student solves $\sqrt{x-2} = -3$ by squaring both sides to obtain $x-2 = 9 \implies x = 11$. Does $x = 11$ satisfy the original equation?

Answer: False.

Method: Substituting $x = 11$ gives $\sqrt{11-2} = \sqrt{9} = 3 \neq -3$. Squaring both sides introduces an extraneous solution where the two sides originally had opposite signs. Thus $x = 11$ does not satisfy the equation.

Investigate further: Under what condition on the right-hand side does $\sqrt{f(x)} = c$ have any real solutions?

2. A student simplifies $\frac{x^2-4}{x-2} = 4 \implies x+2 = 4 \implies x = 2$. Is $x = 2$ a valid solution to the original equation?

Answer: False.

Method: At $x = 2$, the denominator $x-2$ equals 0, so the expression $\frac{x^2-4}{x-2}$ is undefined. The cancellation $\frac{x^2-4}{x-2} = x+2$ is valid only for $x \neq 2$. Thus $x = 2$ is not in the domain of the equation, leaving it with no solutions.

Investigate further: What type of discontinuity does the function $g(x) = \frac{x^2-4}{x-2}$ have at $x = 2$?

3. In an attempted proof that $1 = 2$, a student starts with $a = b$, obtains $(a-b)(a+b) = b(a-b)$, and concludes $a+b = b$. Which algebraic operation is invalid?

Answer: Dividing by $a-b$ (division by zero is invalid).

Method: Since $a = b$, the factor $a-b$ is equal to 0. Dividing both sides of $(a-b)(a+b) = b(a-b)$ by $a-b$ constitutes division by zero, which is undefined.

Investigate further: Why does dividing by zero allow one to prove any arbitrary equality such as $1 = 2$?

4. A student claims that for all real x , $x^2 > 4 \implies x > 2$. Give a negative integer counterexample to this deduction.

Answer: -3

Method: For $x = -3$, $x^2 = 9 > 4$ holds, but $-3 > 2$ is false. Any $x \leq -2$ disproves the claim.

Investigate further: What is the correct equivalence for $x^2 > 4$?

5. A student solves $\log(x) + \log(x-3) = 1$ and finds candidate solutions $x = -2$ and $x = 5$. Which candidate is extraneous?

Answer: -2

Method: For $x = -2$, neither $\log(-2)$ nor $\log(-5)$ is defined for real logarithms, which require strictly positive arguments. Only $x = 5$ is valid: $\log(5) + \log(2) = \log(10) = 1$.

Investigate further: Why does combining $\log(a) + \log(b) = \log(ab)$ expand the domain of definition?

6. A student conjectures: “If $f'(c) = 0$, then f has a local maximum or minimum at $x = c$.” Give a polynomial function $f(x)$ with $c = 0$ that disproves this claim.

Answer: $f(x) = x^3$ (an inflection point, no local extremum).

Method: For $f(x) = x^3$, $f'(x) = 3x^2 \implies f'(0) = 0$. However, $x = 0$ is a stationary point of inflection: $f(x) < 0$ for $x < 0$ and $f(x) > 0$ for $x > 0$, so f has neither a local maximum nor a local minimum at $x = 0$.

Investigate further: What condition on higher derivatives determines whether a stationary point is a local extremum?

7. A student asserts: “ $|a| < |b| \implies a < b$.” Provide a counterexample pair of integers (a, b) .

Answer: $(1, -2)$

Method: For $a = 1$ and $b = -2$, we have $|a| = 1 < 2 = |b|$, but $1 < -2$ is false.

Investigate further: When does $|a| < |b| \implies a < b$ hold?

8. A student concludes that because n^2 is divisible by 4, n must be divisible by 4. Find the smallest positive integer counterexample n .

Answer: 2

Method: For $n = 2$, $n^2 = 4$, which is divisible by 4, but 2 is not divisible by 4. The smallest counterexample is $n = 2$.

Investigate further: If p is prime and $p \mid n^2$, must $p \mid n$?

9. A student claims: “For all real numbers a, b , if $a < b$ then $a^2 < b^2$.” Give a pair of integers (a, b) with $a < b$ and $a^2 > b^2$.

Answer: $(-5, 2)$

Method: For $a = -5$ and $b = 2$, $-5 < 2$ holds, but $a^2 = 25 > 4 = b^2$.

Investigate further: Under what condition on a and b does $a < b \implies a^2 < b^2$ hold?

10. A student asserts: “If $A \subseteq B \cup C$, then $A \subseteq B$ or $A \subseteq C$.” Give a set A of two elements and sets $B = \{1\}, C = \{2\}$ that disprove this claim.

Answer: $A = \{1, 2\}$

Method: Let $A = \{1, 2\}$. Then $A \subseteq \{1\} \cup \{2\} = \{1, 2\}$ holds, but $A \not\subseteq \{1\}$ and $A \not\subseteq \{2\}$.

Investigate further: Is it true that if $x \in B \cup C$, then $x \in B$ or $x \in C$?

Section B

1. A student attempts to prove: “For all integers n , if n is odd, then n^2 is odd.”

Line 1: Suppose n is odd, so $n = 2k + 1$ for some integer k .

Line 2: Then $n^2 = 4k^2 + 4k + 1 = 2(2k^2 + 2k) + 1$.

Line 3: Since $2k^2 + 2k$ is an integer, n^2 is odd.

Is this proof valid? Justify your answer.

Answer: Yes, fully valid.

Method: Every line follows correctly: the algebra in Line 2 is correct ($(2k + 1)^2 = 4k^2 + 4k + 1$), and Line 3 correctly identifies the result as $2 \times (\text{integer}) + 1$, the definition of odd. There is no flaw.

Investigate further: Is this a direct proof or a proof by contrapositive of some related statement?

2. Find the flaw: “Claim: If $x^2 = 3x$, then $x = 3$.” Proof: Divide both sides of $x^2 = 3x$ by x to get $x = 3$.

Answer: Dividing by x is invalid when $x = 0$.

Method: $x^2 = 3x \iff x(x - 3) = 0 \iff x = 0$ or $x = 3$. Dividing by x silently assumes $x \neq 0$ and loses the solution $x = 0$, which also satisfies the original equation.

Investigate further: Rewrite the claim correctly, including both solutions.

3. Find the flaw: “Claim: The only real solution to $\sqrt{x+7} = x - 5$ is $x = 9$.” Proof: Squaring both sides gives $x + 7 = x^2 - 10x + 25$, so $x^2 - 11x + 18 = 0$, so $(x - 9)(x - 2) = 0$, giving $x = 9$ or $x = 2$.

Answer: $x = 2$ is an extraneous root introduced by squaring; it must be checked against and rejected from the original equation.

Method: Checking $x = 2$ in the original equation: $\sqrt{2+7} = \sqrt{9} = 3$, but $x - 5 = 2 - 5 = -3$. Since $3 \neq -3$, $x = 2$ does not satisfy the original equation. Squaring introduced this extraneous solution; only $x = 9$ (which does check: $\sqrt{16} = 4 = 9 - 5$) is valid.

Investigate further: Why does squaring specifically introduce solutions where the two sides had opposite sign?

4. A student argues: For every integer n , $6 \left(\frac{4n+1}{2} - \frac{n-3}{2} \right)$ is a multiple of 3. (*after TMUA 2020 Paper 2 Q3*)

Line 1: $6 \left(\frac{4n+1}{2} - \frac{n-3}{2} \right) = 3 \left(2 \left(\frac{4n+1}{2} - \frac{n-3}{2} \right) \right)$.

Line 2: $= 3(4n + 1 - n - 3)$.

Line 3: $= 3(3n - 2)$.

Line 4: which is always a multiple of 3.

On which line does the argument first contain an error, and what exactly is that error?

Answer: Line 2

Method: Correctly distributing, $2 \left(\frac{4n+1}{2} - \frac{n-3}{2} \right) = (4n + 1) - (n - 3) = 4n + 1 - n + 3 = 3n + 4$, not

$4n + 1 - n - 3$ as written. The sign of -3 was not flipped when distributing the subtraction across the bracket $(n - 3)$. (Interestingly, since Line 1's outer factor of 3 is untouched by this error, the final conclusion — a multiple of 3 — remains true regardless; the argument is still invalid even though its conclusion happens to be correct.)

Investigate further: Compute the genuinely correct simplified form, $3(3n + 4)$, and confirm it is still a multiple of 3.

5. Find the flaw: “Claim: For every integer n , $n^2 + n + 2$ is even.” Proof: If n is even, $n = 2k$, so $n^2 + n + 2 = 4k^2 + 2k + 2 = 2(2k^2 + k + 1)$, which is even. Hence $n^2 + n + 2$ is even for every integer n .

Answer: The proof only checks the even case; the odd case is never addressed.

Method: To prove a claim for “every integer n ”, both parities must be checked. (The claim does happen to also hold for odd n : $n = 2k + 1 \implies n^2 + n + 2 = 4k^2 + 4k + 1 + 2k + 1 + 2 = 4k^2 + 6k + 4 = 2(2k^2 + 3k + 2)$, even — but the proof as given never establishes this.)

Investigate further: Complete the missing odd case explicitly.

6. Find the flaw: “Claim: For real x , $x^2 = 9 \iff x = 3$.” Proof: If $x = 3$, then $x^2 = 9$. This proves the biconditional.

Answer: Only the $\Leftarrow$ direction ($x = 3 \implies x^2 = 9$) was shown; the $\implies$ direction ($x^2 = 9 \implies x = 3$) is false, since $x = -3$ also satisfies $x^2 = 9$.

Method: A biconditional requires both directions to be proved. The correct statement is $x^2 = 9 \iff x = 3$ or $x = -3$.

Investigate further: What is the correct biconditional relating $x^2 = 9$ to a single equation in x ?

7. Find the flaw: “Claim: For every positive integer n , the n -th Fibonacci number F_n (with $F_1 = F_2 = 1$) is either equal to 1 or prime.” Proof: $F_3 = 2$, $F_4 = 3$, $F_5 = 5$ — all prime. Since the pattern holds for $n = 3, 4, 5$, the claim is proved. What is the smallest counterexample?

Answer: Checking finitely many cases does not prove a universal claim; $F_6 = 8 = 2^3$ is the smallest counterexample.

Method: $F_1 = 1, F_2 = 1, F_3 = 2, F_4 = 3, F_5 = 5, F_6 = 8$. $F_6 = 8$ is neither equal to 1 nor prime ($8 = 2 \times 4$), disproving the claim. Three verified cases give no logical guarantee about the fourth.

Investigate further: Is F_n prime for infinitely many n ? This remains an open problem in general.

8. A student wants to prove: “If n is not divisible by 3, then n^2 is not divisible by 3.” Instead, they show: “If n is divisible by 3, then n^2 is divisible by 3.” Explain why this does not prove the original claim.

Answer: The statement shown is neither the original claim nor its contrapositive — it proves nothing about the original.

Method: Original claim: $\neg A \implies \neg B$ where A : “ $3 \mid n$ ”, B : “ $3 \mid n^2$ ”. Its valid contrapositive is $B \implies A$ (“if $3 \mid n^2$ then $3 \mid n$ ”). The student instead proved $A \implies B$, a different (though also true) statement, which establishes neither the original claim nor its contrapositive.

Investigate further: State the actual contrapositive of the original claim, and outline how you would prove it.

9. Find the flaw: “Claim: For all integers a, b , if a and b are both even, then $a + b$ is even.” Proof: Since $a + b$ is even, $a + b = 2m$ for some integer m . Since a, b are even, $a = 2j, b = 2k$, so $2j + 2k = 2m$, i.e. $j + k = m$, which is true since m is an integer. Hence $a + b$ is even.

Answer: Circular reasoning: the proof begins by assuming $a + b$ is even (the very thing to be proved) instead of deriving it.

Method: A correct proof starts from $a = 2j, b = 2k$ and derives $a + b = 2j + 2k = 2(j + k)$, which is even because $j + k$ is an integer — it never needs to assume $a + b = 2m$ up front.

Investigate further: Rewrite this as a correct, non-circular direct proof.

10. A student attempts to solve $\log_2(x - 1) + \log_2(x + 1) = 3$:

Line 1: $\log_2((x - 1)(x + 1)) = 3$.

Line 2: $(x - 1)(x + 1) = 2^3 = 8$.

Line 3: $x^2 - 1 = 8 \implies x^2 = 9$.

Line 4: $x = 3$ or $x = -3$.

Line 5: Hence the solution set is $\{-3, 3\}$.

On which line does the first error occur, and what is the true solution set? (after TMUA 2017 Paper 2 Q13)

Answer: Line 5 (only $x = 3$ is valid in the domain).

Method: Lines 1–4 correctly deduce $x = \pm 3$. However, in the original equation $\log_2(x - 1) + \log_2(x + 1) = 3$, the terms require $x - 1 > 0$ and $x + 1 > 0$, so $x > 1$. The candidate $x = -3$ makes the arguments negative ($\log_2(-4)$ and $\log_2(-2)$), which are undefined. Line 5 fails to verify the domain restriction; the true solution set is $\{3\}$.

Investigate further: Why does combining $\log(a) + \log(b) = \log(ab)$ expand the domain to include points where both a and b are negative?

Section C

1. Consider the claim: “For every positive integer n , $2n^2 + 2n + 1$ is prime.” (after TMUA 2022 Paper 2 Q7)

Answer: D

Method: Lines I–III are correct: the discriminant of $2x^2 + 2x + 1$ is indeed -4 , so the polynomial has no real (let alone integer linear) factorisation. But Line IV commits a category error: a polynomial being irreducible over $\mathbb{Z}[x]$ says nothing about whether its integer OUTPUT VALUES are prime. At $n = 3$: $2(9) + 6 + 1 = 25 = 5^2$, composite, disproving the original claim.

Investigate further: Find another value of n for which $2n^2 + 2n + 1$ is composite.

2. Let P : “ $x^2 - 5x + 6 = 0$ ” and Q : “ $x = 2$ ”. A student argues $Q \implies P$ is true and concludes $P \iff Q$.

Answer: B

Method: $x^2 - 5x + 6 = (x - 2)(x - 3) = 0$, so P is satisfied by $x = 2$ or $x = 3$. $Q \implies P$ is indeed true, but $P \implies Q$ is false since $x = 3$ satisfies P without satisfying Q . Asserting $P \implies Q$ merely because

the statements “seem related” is the flaw.

Investigate further: What is the correct relationship (necessary/sufficient) between P and Q ?

3. A student attempts to prove: “For every integer n , $n^2 + n$ is divisible by 2”, checking only the even case.

Answer: B

Method: $n^2 + n = n(n + 1)$ is a product of two consecutive integers, so it is even regardless of the parity of n — but the given proof only demonstrates this for even n and never addresses odd n , so as written it is incomplete.

Investigate further: Complete the missing odd case: for $n = 2k + 1$, show $n^2 + n$ is even.

4. A student attempts to prove: “No three consecutive odd positive integers can all be prime.” (after TMUA 2023 Paper 2 Q4)

Answer: C

Method: Lines I and II are correct: among $n - 2, n, n + 2$, exactly one is always divisible by 3. Line III is the flaw — being a positive multiple of 3 only implies compositeness if the multiple is *greater than* 3; the multiple could equal 3 itself, which is prime. Exactly this happens at $n = 5$: the three consecutive odd integers 3, 5, 7 are all prime.

Investigate further: Are there any other counterexamples to the original claim besides 3, 5, 7?

5. A student “proves” $\forall n \exists m (m > n)$ and concludes $\exists M \forall n (M > n)$.

Answer: B

Method: Swapping the order of a universal and existential quantifier is not a valid logical step in general. $\forall n \exists m (m > n)$ says every n has SOME larger m (true, e.g. $m = n + 1$); $\exists M \forall n (M > n)$ says a SINGLE M exceeds every n simultaneously, which is false (no integer is larger than every integer).

Investigate further: Give a general example of a true $\forall \exists$ statement whose $\exists \forall$ swap is false.

6. A student “confirms” the converse of “rhombus $\implies$ perpendicular diagonals” using only the example of a square.

Answer: B

Method: One example (the square) supports the converse but cannot prove a universal statement. A kite has perpendicular diagonals but is generally not a rhombus, disproving the converse.

Investigate further: Sketch a kite that is not a rhombus, and confirm its diagonals are perpendicular.

7. A student disproves (*): “For every pair of real numbers x, y , $|x + y| < |x| + |y|$ ” using the pair $x = -2, y = -5$. (after TMUA 2020 Paper 2 Q8)

Answer: D

Method: This is a trap: the student’s reasoning is actually completely correct. (*) as stated uses strict $<$, and at $x = -2, y = -5$ (both negative, hence same sign), $|x + y| = 7 = |x| + |y|$, so $7 < 7$ is false — a fully valid single counterexample to a universal claim. No further pairs need be checked to reject (*).

Investigate further: For which pairs (x, y) does $|x + y| = |x| + |y|$ hold with equality?

8. A student “verifies” “four equal sides $\iff$ square” by checking only that every square has four equal sides.

Answer: B

Method: This checks only necessity (square $\implies$ four equal sides). Sufficiency (four equal sides $\implies$ square) is false: a non-square rhombus has four equal sides but is not a square.

Investigate further: What additional condition, combined with “four equal sides”, would give a genuine necessary and sufficient characterisation of a square?

Section D

1. A flawed attempt to prove: if $s^2 \geq 4p$ then there exist real u, v with $u + v = s, uv = p$. (after TMUA 2021 Paper 2 Q11)

Answer: B

Method: Every algebraic step (II, III) is correct, but the logical direction is backward. The student assumed u, v exist and derived $s^2 \geq 4p$ from that assumption — this proves the CONVERSE of the theorem, not the theorem itself. A correct proof constructs u, v directly: let u, v be the two roots of $t^2 - st + p = 0$; since the discriminant $s^2 - 4p \geq 0$, these roots are real, and by Vieta’s formulas $u + v = s, uv = p$.

Investigate further: Why does the discriminant condition $s^2 - 4p \geq 0$ guarantee the roots of $t^2 - st + p = 0$ are real?

2. A student claims “ $n^2 - n + 11$ prime $\implies n^2 + n + 11$ prime” for all positive n , verified for $n = 1, \dots, 9$.

Answer: (a) Finite verification is not a universal proof. (b) $n = 10$.

Method: (a) Checking 9 cases gives no guarantee about $n = 10$ or beyond — a single unchecked value could be a counterexample.

(b) At $n = 10$: $n^2 - n + 11 = 100 - 10 + 11 = 101$, which is prime (premise true). But $n^2 + n + 11 = 100 + 10 + 11 = 121 = 11^2$, which is NOT prime (conclusion false). So the implication fails at $n = 10$, the smallest such value since $n = 1, \dots, 9$ were verified to hold.

Investigate further: Verify that $n^2 - n + 11$ is prime for $n = 1, \dots, 9$ by computing the first few values.

3. Evaluate a contradiction-style proof that “ ab even $\implies a$ even or b even”.

Answer: D) I and II only

Method: The algebra $(2j + 1)(2k + 1) = 4jk + 2j + 2k + 1 = 2(2jk + j + k) + 1$ is correct, so III is false. Statement I is true: assuming the negation (a, b both odd) and deriving a contradiction (ab odd, contradicting ab even) is a valid contradiction proof. Statement II is also true: the derivation “ a, b both odd $\implies ab$ odd” is exactly the contrapositive of the original claim (contrapositive of ab even $\implies (a$ even or b even) is $\neg(a$ even or b even) $\implies \neg(ab$ even), i.e. “ a, b both odd $\implies ab$ odd”), proved here directly without needing the “suppose for contradiction” framing at all.

Investigate further: Rewrite this proof in pure contrapositive form, removing the contradiction framing entirely.

4. Evaluate the “every odd prime > 3 has the form $6k \pm 1$ ” argument.

Answer: B

Method: Every line is correct: $6k, 6k+2, 6k+4$ are even (Line 2, correctly dismissed); $6k+3 = 3(2k+1)$ is a multiple of 3 exceeding 3 whenever $k \geq 1$, and the case $k = 0$ giving exactly 3 is excluded by the claim's own hypothesis "greater than 3" (Line 3, correctly handled). The proof only ever claimed to show that primes > 3 MUST have the form $6k \pm 1$ (necessity) — it never claimed every number of that form IS prime (sufficiency), and the original claim, read carefully, only asserts the former. So there is no actual gap.

Investigate further: Give an example of a number of the form $6k+1$ that is not prime, to confirm sufficiency genuinely fails.

5. Evaluate: "For all $n \geq 2$, $n^2 - 1$ is composite", proved via $n^2 - 1 = (n-1)(n+1)$.

Answer: (a) Line 3. (b) $n = 2$; and $n = 2$ is the unique exception.

Method: (a) Line 3 is the gap: a product of two integers each "at least 1" is not necessarily composite — compositeness requires BOTH factors to be at least 2. Line 2 only guarantees $n-1 \geq 1$, not $n-1 \geq 2$. (b) At $n = 2$: $n^2 - 1 = 3 = 1 \times 3$. The factor of 1 does not make 3 composite — 3 is prime, so the conclusion genuinely fails here. *Proof that $n = 2$ is the only failure:* for every $n \geq 3$, $n-1 \geq 2$ and $n+1 \geq 4$, so $n^2 - 1 = (n-1)(n+1)$ is a product of two integers both at least 2, which is precisely the definition of composite — no case analysis or further checking is needed once $n \geq 3$, since the factorisation itself, together with $n-1 \geq 2$, is a fully general and complete argument covering every such n simultaneously.

Investigate further: Why does the same style of argument fail to show $n^2 - 4$ is composite for all $n \geq 3$? (Check $n = 3$: $n^2 - 4 = 5$.)

Top 5 Patterns Today

- 1. The Converse Error (Affirming the Consequent).** Arguing that $P \Rightarrow Q$ and observing Q implies P is the classic converse fallacy; observing a necessary condition holding never proves the sufficient premise. (see B6, C2, C6, C8, D1)
- 2. The Inverse Error (Denying the Antecedent).** Arguing that $P \Rightarrow Q$ and concluding $\neg P \Rightarrow \neg Q$ confuses an implication with its inverse; multiple distinct conditions often produce the exact same consequence. (see B8, D3, C2)
- 3. Extraneous Roots from Non-Reversible Operations.** Squaring both sides of $\sqrt{f(x)} = g(x)$ or applying logarithm product rules introduces false solutions where the original expressions were undefined or opposite in sign. (see A1, A2, A5, B3, B10)
- 4. Division by Zero and Root Loss.** Dividing both sides of an equation by a variable expression (e.g. $x^2 = 3x \Rightarrow x = 3$ or dividing by $a - b$) implicitly assumes that factor is nonzero, erasing valid roots or fabricating false contradictions. (see A2, A3, B2, D5)
- 5. Incomplete Case Analysis and Boundary Gaps.** Proving a claim only for even n , or ignoring boundary values where factors equal 1 ($n = 2$ in $(n-1)(n+1)$), leaves unexamined cases that often harbour the unique counterexample. (see B5, B7, C3, D2, D5)

Common Traps to Avoid

- 1. The Fallacy Fallacy (Refuting Argument vs Refuting Claim).** Demonstrating that a proof contains an invalid step shows only that the proof fails, not that the conclusion itself is

false; a true proposition can easily be given an invalid proof. (see B4, C1, D2)

2. Losing Valid Roots via Direct Variable Division. Cancelling a factor x from $x^2 = kx$ discards the root $x = 0$; always factorise into $x(x - k) = 0$ rather than dividing through by unknown quantities. (see A2, A3, B2, D5)

3. Accepting Extraneous Solutions After Squaring or Logs. Squaring an equation maps both positive and negative values to positive numbers; all solutions found after squaring or logarithm products must be verified against original domains. (see A1, A5, B3, B10)

4. Assuming “Checking Cases” Equals Proof for Universals. Verifying that an algebraic property holds for several small integers ($n = 1, 2, 3$) is merely inductive evidence; universal claims fail if even a single case or parity class is omitted. (see B5, B7, C3, D2)

5. Circular Reasoning (Begging the Question). Assuming the conclusion in order to simplify an intermediate expression produces an argument that appears valid on the surface but is logically vacuous. (see B9, C4)

“Speed comes from recognition, not from rushing. Every shortcut is a pattern you have internalised.”

Found a mistake or want to contribute a sheet?

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